Silver Oaks Model United Nations
ECOSOC Background Guide



ECOSOC

Letter from the Executive Board:

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the 8th Edition of Silver Oaks Model United Nations! It is both a privilege and a pleasure to introduce you to our committee, the Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC). As your Executive Board, we are here not only to guide the flow of debate but also to ensure that your MUN experience is intellectually stimulating, collaborative, and memorable.

This Background Guide has been carefully prepared with one clear purpose: to serve as a foundation for your research and a roadmap to help you navigate the committee. It provides context on the mandate and functioning of ECOSOC, as well as an introduction to this year's agenda. However, we want to emphasize that **this guide is not meant to confine your ideas or limit your scope**. Think of it as a starting point, an invitation to dig deeper, explore multiple perspectives, and form your own unique strategies as delegates.

Throughout the 3 days of the conference, we would look towards a healthy amount of discussion and debate. Please note that **there is no such thing as a "good" country and a "bad" country**. Every single country is **EQUAL** when it comes to an international forum of communications. We, your Executive Board, would look towards your diplomacy, understanding of the committee and the agenda, and your debating skills. If this is your first time attending a Model United Nations conference, don't worry, we are always there to help you out.

The agenda for this year, "**Addressing Multinational Corruption via Illicit Activities Affecting the Socio-Economic Status of States, with Special Emphasis on the Role of MNCs and Governmental Bodies**," addresses a pressing yet underexplored global challenge. Corruption increasingly undermines institutions, deepens socio-economic inequalities, and distorts economic and political systems. With MNCs and governmental bodies playing influential roles, balancing development, accountability, and transparency makes this a timely issue for ECOSOC's deliberation.

This agenda was created on fact that multinational corruption is one such issue which undermines the founding principles of the United Nations as a whole and affects the socio-economic status of countries which directly and indirectly affects us as citizens of the world. The discussions that we would have will bring in topics covering accountability and solutions that countries can take to tackle the issue of Multinational Corruption.

We are genuinely excited to see the perspectives you bring to the table, the alliances you build, and the solutions you shape. This conference is not just about resolutions, it's about learning, exchanging ideas, and discovering the diplomat within you.

Wishing you all the very best as you embark on this journey. Let's make this committee a space for meaningful debate, impactful collaboration, and lasting memories.

Warm regards,

Soham Mohanty – Chairperson

K Jahnavi Akshaya – Vice Chairperson

Arshit Sai Nagolu – Rapporteur

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Tips from the Executive Board and Key Pointers to Note:

1. Be very thorough with your Foreign Policy: Foreign policy (FP) is the set of goals, strategies, and actions that a state or a non-state actor pursues in its relations with other actors in the international system. Foreign policy reflects the interests, values, and preferences of the actor, and it guides its decisions and behaviours in the global arena. Foreign trade policy is a subtype of foreign policy that focuses on the regulation and promotion of the exchange of goods and services between the actor and other actors in the international system. Note that **no specific document** exists in which a state or a non-state actor's foreign policy. Understanding your FP should take up a good chunk of your research as it helps you understand your portfolio from all possible angles.
2. Usage of Artificial Intelligence: **Use AI as a tool, don't rely/depend on it.** Use it to understand your research and validate your statistics. There will be an AI limit for documentation which shall be revealed when the time is appropriate. When it comes to speeches, we highly suggest you to make your speeches on your own as an AI speech can easily be distinguished from a non-AI speech and it can affect your marking.
3. Credibility of Information: Whenever you are researching, always keep these tiers in mind to know what source is most credible and what isn't.
    - Tier 1 – UN Websites (UN Sourced) Documents, Resolutions, Official UN reports, etc., Reuters;
    - Tier 2 – Government Websites, Official Government Media (Xinhua News Agency – China, TASS – Russia, BelTA – Belarus, etc…);
    - Tier 3 – News Reports – not preferred as they generally provide biased opinions but is good for transcriptions.

    [NOTE: Sources like Youtuber Content and Wikipedia are NOT ACCEPTED at all. In conflicts of information, this tier system and the date of that article, statement, or release, etc… would be taken into consideration.]
4. Chits may be submitted in any **officially recognized UN language**. However, an English translation must be provided for all non-English chits.
5. **Every delegate** is expected to speak once (at least) during the proceedings of the committee. Substantive Chits **do not count** as speeches.

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Rules of Procedure:

Formal Debate:

GSL (General Speakers List): The General Speakers List shows the order of speakers for the topic being on agenda and is open for the whole duration of the discussion. Speaking time for the General Speaker´s List is set to 90 seconds. The time limit can be altered by a Motion to Change the Speaker´s Time. The Speaker´s List is open just for the topic currently being on the agenda.

Informal Debate:

Moderated Caucus: A Moderated Caucus is aimed to facilitate and accelerate the discussion on the issues deemed as essential and critical for the topic on agenda. The delegate shall specify the total time of discussion and the individual speaker´s time for each of the delegates (not exceeding the speaker´s time set for the General Speakers List) and a topic. The purpose, i.e. the topic of the Motion shall be connected to the issue currently being discussed on the agenda and shall be more particular that the general topic of the discussion.

Unmoderated Caucus: Consider it to a break/informal session where delegates can freely decide on the upcoming topics of discussion.

Formal Consultations: Like a moderated caucus but works on an on-spot recognition basis where delegates make short and crisp statements on the agenda (or a proposed sub-agenda). It is preferred to have a formal consultation speech of up to 30 seconds but delegates can raise their placards to give another speech during the same consultation session. A delegate must specify a total speakers' time but no individual speaker's time.

Informal Consultations: Like a formal consultation but does not include a formal recognition basis. Delegates can stand up and start speaking but should not interrupt a speaker. It is preferred to have an informal consultation speech of up to 15-20 seconds but delegates can stand up and give another speech during the same consultation session. A delegate must specify a total speakers' time but no individual speaker's time.

Round Robins: A mode of discussion where every delegate gives a one-minute speech. There will be no recognition process as the order of speeches happening in alphabetical order (of the countries' names), reverse alphabetical order, or in the committee seating arrangement. A delegate must specify a total speakers' time but no individual speaker's time as the individual speaker's time is automatically set to one-minute per speaker.

[NOTE: Formal Consultations, Informal Consultations and Round Robins are not part of the typical UNA – USA Rules of Procedure but since they add a healthy amount of discussion and debate, it would be a preferred mode of discussion.]

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Overview of the Committee:

- Established in 1945, ECOSOC is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations.
- Promotes economic, social, and environmental development and works towards achieving the SDGs.
- Facilitates policy discussions, develops recommendations, and builds international consensus on global challenges.
- Coordinates UN bodies, regional commissions, and international organisations to improve cooperation on development issues.
- Monitors progress on commitments made at major UN conferences and summits and assesses their impact.
- Provides a platform for governments, NGOs, businesses, academics, and youth to contribute to global policy discussions.
- ECOSOC primarily makes recommendations and coordinates action; it does not directly impose domestic laws on member states.
- At the 2005 World Summit, in paragraph 155 of the World Summit Outcome Document, Heads of State and Government mandated the Economic and Social Council with ensuring the follow-up of the outcomes of the major United Nations conferences and summits, including the internationally agreed development goals, and to hold annual ministerial-level substantive reviews (AMRs) to assess progress, drawing on its functional and regional commissions and other international institutions, in accordance with their respective mandates.

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Overview of the Agenda:

corruption

Term

Source: E/C.16/2006/4, para 50 (5 Jan 2006);

Definition

Dishonest or fraudulent conduct by those in power, typically involving bribery.

It is a fact that corruption is now universal. This means exists in all countries, both developed and developing, in the public and private sectors, as well as in non-profit and charitable organizations.

On an international scale, corruption generally happens in two ways:

a) Within multiple countries – meaning, it is seen in multiple countries that affects the socio-economic status of the country in which corruption is taking place.
b) Between multiple countries – meaning, corruption in one country/from one country is affecting another country.

Now this multinational corruption generally happens through corrupt officials who:

a) Hold a government office
b) Hold a position in a Multinational Corporation (MNC).

A few notable examples:

1) The Uzbekistan telecommunications bribery case (2016) – VEON Ltd. formerly known as VimpelCom Ltd. wanted to expand their mobile phone business in Uzbekistan. The company decided to use “unfair” methods to achieve this goal. They admitted to paying more than $144 million in bribes to a government official between 2006 and 2012. Through this, the official helped the company to gain access and licenses to operate in the country. The money was wired through overseas bank accounts to conceal the identity of the payer. Later, VimpelCom paid an approximate of $795 million in penalties alone.

2) The defence procurement bribery case involving the Qatar Emiri Air Force and Raytheon (2012-2016) – Between 2012 and 2016, Raytheon employees and agents had bribed a senior Qatari military official to help "secure" defence contracts. The payments were disguised as legitimate contracts for studies and other services. The case exposed how corruption within public defence procurement can undermine fair competition and influence how governments spend public money.

Corruption has existed throughout history and has affected the functioning of governments and societies in different ways. As economies and international relations developed, corruption gradually became more complex, extending beyond individual states and involving businesses, governments, and financial systems. The growing interconnectedness of countries has therefore made corruption an increasingly important international concern, particularly because of its impact on economic development, public institutions, and the well-being of societies.

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Relevance to the 2030 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs):

ECOSOC is one of the key bodies responsible for the guidance, coordination, and implementation of the 2030 Agenda of Sustainable Development.

The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development is divided into 17 SDGs. This framework was adopted by UN Member States in 2015.

The Mandate of ECOSOC primarily looks over:

- SDG 1: No Poverty
- SDG 3: Good Health and Well-Being
- SDG 4: Quality Education
- SDG 5: Gender Equality
- SDG 8: Decent Work and Economic Growth
- SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities
- SDG 13: Climate Action
- SDG 17: Partnership for the Goals
- SDG 16: Peace, Justice and Strong Institutions

ECOSOC helps the High-Level Political Forum (HLPF) to review the progress made by countries towards these goals.

A few suggestions from the Executive Board on this matter:

1. Understand how corruption affects the achievement of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.
2. Examine the relationship between corruption, institutional accountability and sustainable economic and social development.
3. Consider the role of the SDGs as a **framework** for evaluating the long-term impact of corruption.
4. Explore how anti-corruption measures can contribute to **sustainable development** across Member States.

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Examples for Reference:

MNC-led Corruption Example:

Some companies have been involved in bribery to obtain business contracts, licences, or other commercial advantages. Such practices can affect fair competition and the way businesses interact with governments.

An example is the Telia corruption case in Uzbekistan. In 2017, the telecommunications company Telia and its Uzbek subsidiary agreed to a global settlement exceeding US$965 million with authorities. According to the US Department of Justice, the companies admitted to paying approximately US$331 million in bribes to an Uzbek government official to obtain telecommunications business in the country.

This case shows how corporate interests can become connected to corrupt practices and raises questions about the responsibility of multinational companies when conducting business across national borders.

Transnational Corruption Network Example:

Corruption may involve networks of individuals, and companies operating across several countries. These connections can make it difficult to trace the movement of illegal funds and identify the people who ultimately benefit from them.

The 1Malaysia Development Berhad (1MDB) case in Malaysia clearly shows this issue. According to the US Department of Justice, more than US$4.5 billion belonging to Malaysia's state investment fund was misused between 2009 and 2015 through a scheme involving embezzlement and international money laundering. The funds were transferred through financial institutions across few jurisdictions. By June 2024, nearly US$1.4 billion had been returned to Malaysia through recovery efforts led by the department.

This case shows the challenges of investigating financial activities that cross nations. It also highlights the importance of cooperation between countries and international institutions when tracing funds and recovering assets linked to corruption.

Example of Corruption led by Governmental Bodies:

When public officials accept bribes or misuse their authority, public projects and government decisions can be influenced by private interests.

An example is the Lesotho Highlands Water Project in Lesotho. The project involved major infrastructure development, and in its process of buying became the subject of corruption investigations. According to the World Bank and United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime's Stolen Asset Recovery Initiative, Masupha Ephraim Sole, the former chief executive of the Lesotho Highlands Development Authority, was found guilty of accepting bribes from multinational companies seeking project contracts.

The case shows how corruption involving public officials and private companies can affect the management of large public projects. It also raises questions about government oversight, transparency in procurement, and accountability for decisions involving public resources

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